

That's not Meta

So, Facebook is Meta now. If you're a gamer, you realise how odd that sounds because Facebook has been anything but meta for the past few years. Will changing the name make much of a difference? Who knows. The 'meta' Facebook is going for is derived from the Greek word *meta*, which means 'after' or 'beyond'. For us gamers though, meta has an entirely different meaning, the most effective tactic available. Meta.

Anyway, what does Mark Zuckerberg's "metaverse" bring to the table? At least on the gaming front of things; we don't really care about the rest. Socialising? Pffft. In his words, we can do anything you can imagine in this metaverse. "In this future, you will be able to teleport instantly as a hologram to be at the office without commute, at a concert with friends, or in your parents' living room to catch up. This will open up more opportunities, no matter where you live. You'll be able to spend more time on what matters to you, cut down time in traffic, and reduce your carbon footprint."

That sounds pretty cool, to be honest. On paper, at least. The first thing that comes to mind is something like *Ready Player One*, or even the recent *Free Guy* movie, in a way. The world is going virtual.

The demonstrations we've seen so far just look like slightly better VR. So you're going to need a VR headset I'm assuming, which in turn already puts a barrier on the number of people that can use Meta in the way advertised. Facebook does own Oculus, so there's another revenue angle in it for them. This also means they certainly know their way around VR technology and hardware, so I don't really have any doubts about how the experience might be.

What I'm most interested in about Meta is that Zuckerberg announced it will be a collaborative effort between creators and developers. Naturally, we want game devs to jump in on this, and see



where it goes. In a virtual world, the possibilities are, quite literally, limitless. Imagine being able to switch between games by teleporting from one game to another. Imagine being able to take items from one game into another, and the item actually working the same way in the other game. In this virtual world, all your stuff would theoretically be tied to one account, and not several different accounts with different games. That's the metaverse for ya. I'm definitely curious to know what will come out of it.

Facebook, the social media platform, will still remain 'Facebook' though, and try as it might, it's never going to be 'meta' again.

—Manish "Trigger-Happy" Rajesh

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